promised that they would be allowed to return, which never happened. Most of the commanders who were ideologically affiliated with Mapam's Left did not hesitate to expel and destroy the Arab residents when military necessities overcame ideological considerations.

The question of the return of the refugees to their homes arose for the first time when the first truce came into effect in June 1948, as a result of the "trickle" of refugees returning to their homes and the Arab pressure to enable this return. The government, headed by Ben-Gurion, was forced to deal with this issue in two contexts; the first was internationally, in the framework of Israel's foreign relations with the United States, the United Nations, and the Arab states, and the second involved the relations between Mapai, the ruling party, and its coalition partner Mapam, which called for a binational state. A compromise resolution was adopted at a June 16 cabinet meeting: there would be no return of refugees as long as the war was in progress. At the conclusion of the war the issue would be revisited. This decision gave Israel some breathing room vis-à-vis its foreign relations and also ensured the survival of the Mapai-Mapam coalition government.

International treatment of the refugee problem began in 1948, in parallel with the War of Independence. Three international actors were involved:

1. Count Folke Bernadotte, the UN mediator, who demonstrated a hostile attitude toward Israel during his six weeks on the job. Before being assassinated by members of the Lehi—a prestate paramilitary organization—he left an interim report in September 1948 that became his "will and testament" and that was indeed honored by the UN and the superpowers. The basis of Bernadotte's report was that the refugees' right to return to their homes and lands was *absolute* and could not be disputed by any party.
2. The United States, via the State Department and President Truman's personal representative to the United Nations Palestine Conciliation Commission, Mark Ethridge, a Baptist from the South who maintained direct personal correspondence with the American president and who supported Count Bernadotte's views and recommendations.
3. The British government, whose representatives on the ground had to contend with the reality of the Balfour Declaration and its concrete implications, on the one hand, and, on the other, a solution to the